

The Absurd Ark

An IELTS Vocabulary Novel



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CHAPTER 0

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CHAPTER 0.

Introduction

In the year 2030, the Earth decided it had enough. It wasn't just global warming; it was a full-scale geological rebellion. Our protagonist, Dr. Aris (a brilliant but anxious geologist), is trying to warn the world's richest man, a tech tycoon named Leon Husk (a fictional parody), about the impending doom.

CHAPTER 1.

The Crust is Toast

Focus: Physical Geography, Natural Disasters

Plot: Earth is doomed. The decision to flee.

The **atmosphere** inside the conference room was heavier than the **smog** outside. Dr. Aris pointed desperately at the holographic **globe** spinning in the center of the room.

“Mr. Husk, please look at the data,” Aris pleaded. “The **lithosphere** is cracking. We are detecting abnormal **seismic** activity from the **Equator** to the **Antarctic**. This isn’t just a **mishap**; it is a **catastrophic** event in the making.”

Leon Husk, busy playing with a magnetic **pebble** he found on his private **beach**, didn’t look up. “Aris, you worry too much. Is it just another **El Nino phenomenon**? Or maybe a seasonal **monsoon**?”

“No!” Aris shouted, slamming his hand on the table. “The **core** of the Earth is unstable! The **magma** is rising through the **mantle** and pressing against the **crust**. We are looking at a global **calamity**. Yesterday, a **volcano** that has been **dormant** for centuries suddenly **erupted** in the **Pacific** Ocean. It caused a **tsunami** that swallowed an entire **peninsula**!”

Leon finally paused. “A tsunami? Did it hit my factory?”

“Forget the factory! The **terrain** is changing. **glaciers** are melting at an **unprecedented** rate, causing **flooding** in the low-lying **plains**. Meanwhile, the **interior** of the **continent** is suffering from severe **drought**. The **landscape** is turning into a **barren desert**. If we don’t leave, we will be buried under **debris** and **sediment**.”

Leon stood up and walked to the window. Outside, a **gale** was blowing, and a **downpour** of acidic rain obscured the **horizon**. The **climate** had indeed **deteriorated**.

“Okay,” Leon said, his eyes gleaming with a **spark** of madness. “If the **terrestrial** environment is **toxic**, we go up. Prepare the **spacecraft**. We need to reach a safe **altitude** before the **typhoon** hits.”

“You mean... leave Earth?” Aris asked, trembling.

“Yes,” Leon grinned. “We are going to explore the **cosmos**. I heard Mars has a nice **valley** view this time of year. Plus, no **hurricanes** there.”

Aris looked at the **lightning** flashing across the **stormy** sky. It was a **dilemma**, but sticking around for the **avalanche** of doom seemed like a bad idea.

“Fine,” Aris sighed. “But we need to calculate the **orbit** precisely. One wrong move, and we burn up in the **atmosphere**.”

CHAPTER 2.

The Mutant Menagerie

Focus: Botany, Zoology, Conservation

Plot: Visiting the mutant biology lab on the Ark.

Location: “The Ark” - A massive biodome hidden in a remote desert.

Dr. Aris stepped out of the helicopter and gasped. Before him stood a gigantic glass structure, a self-contained ecosystem designed to preserve Earth’s life.

“Welcome to the Jungle... literally,” Leon grinned. “This is where we conduct our **botany** and **zoology** experiments. We need to select the best **flora** and **fauna** to take with us.”

They entered the greenhouse. The air was hot and humid, thick with the scent of weird flowers. Aris noticed that the **vegetation** here was bizarre. There were vines as thick as a man’s arm climbing up the pillars, and gigantic **mushrooms** (a type of **fungus**) growing on rotting logs.

“How is this possible?” Aris asked, touching a leaf.

“Science!” Leon replied. “We use **hybridization** to combine different **species**. Look at this.” He pointed to a plant with red **blossoms**. “It performs **photosynthesis** twenty times faster than normal. It absorbs **carbon dioxide** and releases pure **oxygen** instantly. However, it requires a lot of **fertilizer**.”

“And the animals?” Aris asked, hearing a low roar.

“Ah, the **mammals** are over there,” Leon led him to a fenced area. “We have a team of **biologists** working on them. We need animals that can **reproduce** quickly and **evolve** to handle Mars’ radiation.”

Aris looked into a cage. Inside was a creature that looked like a lion, but it had the **scales** of a **reptile**. “Is that... a **carnivore**?”

“Strictly speaking, it’s an **omnivore** now,” Leon shrugged. “We tweaked its **genes** to fix a **mutation**. Now it eats **hay** and **straw** like a **herbivore**, but it retains the **hunting instinct** of a **predator**. We call it the ‘Lio-sheep’. It produces excellent **wool** and milk.”

Aris was horrified. “This is **unethical**! You are treating living **organisms** like machines. What if a **virus** or **bacteria** spreads among them? An **epidemic** in space would cause the **extinction** of the entire crew!”

“Relax,” Leon waved his hand, disturbing a **swarm** of **mosquitoes**. “These insects are not **pests**. They are genetically modified **parasites** that clean our skin. Totally eco-friendly.”

Suddenly, a loud **hiss** came from the **swamp** section. An **amphibian** the size of a car crawled out of the **muddy** water.

“Oh, that’s just Gary,” Leon said casually. “He’s our **waste** management system. He creates **compost** to help the seeds **germinate**.”

Aris watched a **butterfly** with transparent **wings** land on a **branch**. “Leon, this **biodiversity** is chaotic. The **food chain** is broken. If we don’t **cultivate** these plants carefully, they will **wither** and **decay**. And if these **beasts** aren’t **tamed**, they will **devour** us before we even reach **orbit**.”

Leon checked his watch. “Noted. But right now, we have to load the **cargo**. The **monsoon** is coming, and I don’t want the **hail** to smash the glass roof. Let’s grab the **seeds**, the **embryos**, and get moving.”

Aris looked at the **herd** of mutant cows chewing on **synthetic** grass. He realized that saving humanity might be weirder than the apocalypse itself.

CHAPTER 3.

The Classroom in the Void

Focus: Space Exploration, Education, Math/Physics

Plot: Mandatory learning during space flight.

Location: “The Ark” - Leaving Earth’s Orbit.

The launch was **cataclysmic**. The **spacecraft** shuddered as the massive **propulsion** system fought against Earth’s **gravity**. Inside the command module, Dr. Aris felt the overwhelming **pressure** pinning him to his seat.

“We are approaching the escape **velocity**!” Leon shouted over the roar. “Prepare for zero-G!”

Suddenly, the shaking stopped. A pencil began to **float** in the air. Through the reinforced window, the **curve** of the Earth was visible—a glowing blue **sphere** against the infinite darkness of the **cosmos**. They had entered **orbit**.

“Beautiful, isn’t it?” Leon unbuckled his seatbelt. “The **universe** is our new playground. But Aris, to survive in this **interstellar** environment, you are currently an **idiot**.”

Aris blinked. “Excuse me? I have a PhD (Doctor) in Geology!”

“That’s **terrestrial** thinking,” Leon scoffed. “Up here, you are a **novice**, a complete **fresher**. Welcome to Husk University. I am your **principal**, **headmaster**, and **mentor**. You are the only **pupil**.”

Leon floated over to a high-tech screen and pulled up a digital **timetable**. “This is your new **curriculum**. It’s **compulsory**. No **truancy** allowed.”

Aris looked at the **schedule**. It was a nightmare.

08:00 - **Quantum Mechanics & Particle Physics**

10:00 - **Astronomy**: Mapping the **Galaxy**

12:00 - **Calculus & Geometry**: Calculating **Trajectories**

14:00 - Alien Psychology (Optional **Elective**)

“I have to learn **calculus** again?” Aris groaned. “I hated **maths** in **primary** school.”

“It’s a **prerequisite** for survival!” Leon insisted. “If you can’t solve a simple **equation** about the **radius** of a **meteorite** or the **density** of a **comet**, we will crash! We need to calculate the **dimension** and **mass** of every **chunk** of space **debris** to avoid a **collision**.”

Leon handed Aris a heavy tablet. “Here is your **textbook**. I expect you to **acquire** this **knowledge** by tomorrow. You will have to **submit** a **thesis** on the **composition** of Martian **dust**. And don’t try to

plagiarise from the ship's database. I have software to **detect** cheating. If you fail, I will **suspend** your **food** rations."

"This is **abuse**!" Aris argued. "I can't **cram** all this **information** in one day. My **brain** can't handle this **intensity**."

"Be **diligent**, Aris!" Leon floated upside down. "Use your **intelligence**. We are on a scientific **expedition**. You need to **master** the **principles** of **aerodynamics** and **thermodynamics**. Look at the **spectrum** of that star over there. Is it emitting **ultraviolet** or **radioactive** waves? You need to **analyse** the **signal** from our **antenna**."

Aris sighed and looked at the **diagram** of a **circuit** board Leon wanted him to fix. "What happens if I pass?"

"Then I will grant you a **degree**," Leon smiled. "A Master of Mars. And maybe a **scholarship**—which means I won't charge you a **fee** for the oxygen you breathe."

"You were going to charge me?"

"Of course. Nothing is free, not even in a **vacuum**. Now, stop complaining and start your **assignment**. The **deadline** is when we pass the Moon."

Aris floated to the corner, clutching his tablet. He opened the first chapter: "How to fix a fusion reactor with a spoon." It was going to be a long semester.

CHAPTER 4.

The Gizmo that Saved the World

Focus: Technology, Items & Materials, Fashion

Plot: The ship breaks down. Repairing high-tech gear with style.

Location: The Main Engineering Deck of “The Ark”.

It was a Tuesday (probably), and Leon decided it was time to launch his new **interstellar fashion** brand.

“Aris, look at me!” Leon twirled in the center of the control room. He was wearing a **tight**, shiny **silver outfit** made of **synthetic fiber**. It featured a high **collar**, long **sleeves adorned** with fake **gems** and **beads**, and a massive, flowing **velvet cape**. “I call this look ‘The Cosmic King’. It’s going to be the new **vogue**. A total **trend**.”

Aris, who was busy trying to **calculate** the ship’s fuel consumption using a **digital gauge**, didn’t look up. “Leon, that **costume** looks **ridiculous**. It’s not **stylish**; it looks like you wrapped yourself in **metal sheets**.”

“You have no taste for **luxury** or **elegance**,” Leon scoffed, adjusting his **belt**. “This is **high-definition** beauty. My **fans** on Earth are watching this on the **wireless network**. I am their **icon**, their **idol**.”

Leon walked over to the main **ventilation** unit to pose for the **camera**. “Look at the **texture** of this **fabric**,” he bragged, leaning against the **intake fan**.

Suddenly, disaster struck.

A **gust** of air sucked the hem of Leon’s **velvet cape** into the spinning **blades** of the fan. *ZZZZT! CRACK!*

The **fan** jammed. The **motor** screeched. Sparks flew from the **switch** board.

“My cape!” Leon shrieked. “The ship!” Aris yelled.

Red lights flashed on the **screen**. A robotic voice announced: “*Critical error. Ventilation system failure. Oxygen circulation stopped. Hydraulic pressure dropping.*”

“You broke the air scrubber!” Aris panicked. He rushed to the **emergency cabinet** and grabbed a **kit** full of **tools**. “I need to fix this before we suffocate!”

“Well, hurry up!” Leon demanded, trying to untangle his **shredded** cape. “This is a **fashion** emergency! My **image** is being ruined!”

Aris ignored him. He needed to be a **mechanic** now, not a geologist. He opened the machine's **shutter** and peered inside. It was a **mess**. The **cape** had tangled around the main **gear** and the **pivot**. The **friction** had caused the **rubber belt** to snap.

"I need materials!" Aris shouted. "Leon, bring me the **spare parts box** from the **storage**!"

Leon ran and came back with a **bin** full of **junk**: old **cables**, a **broken toaster**, a **plastic bucket**, and a **tube** of **glue**.

"This is **garbage**!" Aris cried. "I need a **wrench** or a **screwdriver**!"

"Use your imagination! **Improvise**!" Leon said unhelpfully.

Aris took a deep breath. He had to **devise** a solution. He saw a loose **bolt** and a rusted **screw**. He used a metal **spoon** (from his lunch) as a lever to pry open the **casing**. He found the broken **circuit**.

"I need to **connect** these wires," Aris muttered. He stripped the **insulation** off a **cord** using a pair of **scissors**. He realized he didn't have soldering **equipment**, so he used a piece of **gum** (Leon was chewing it) to stick the wires together temporarily. "It's a crude **technique**, but it might work."

Next, the **gear**. It was stuck. "I need **lubricant**!" Leon handed him a bottle of expensive **shampoo**. "It's silky smooth." "Fine!" Aris poured the **shampoo** onto the **gear**. It became slippery. He grabbed the tangled **fabric** and pulled. *Rip!* The cape came free.

Finally, the snapped **belt**. Aris looked at Leon. "Give me your **leather belt**." "What? This is genuine Italian **leather**! It cost a fortune!" "Give it to me, or we die!" Leon sighed and handed it over. Aris used a **knife** to trim the **edge**, punched a hole with a **nail**, and wrapped it around the **wheel**.

He flipped the **switch**. *Whirrrr...*

The **fan** started to spin. The **generator** hummed. The red warning light on the **monitor** turned green. Fresh air began to **circulate** again.

Aris collapsed on the **floor**, wiping **grease** and **sweat** from his forehead with a **rag**. He looked at his **shabby**, oil-stained clothes.

Leon stood up, smoothing his torn **garment**. "Well," he said, looking at the camera. "As I was saying... this **distressed** look is the latest **trend**. It symbolizes the **fragile** nature of human existence."

Aris threw the **wrench** (imaginary wrench) at him.

CHAPTER 5.

Culture Shock in a Can

Focus: Culture & History, Language, Social Roles

Plot: Leon tries to design a future Martian civilization.

Location: The Recreation Room (now converted into a “Throne Room”).

Three weeks into the **voyage**, cabin fever had set in. Aris walked into the mess hall to find Leon sitting on a pile of boxes, wearing a makeshift crown made of **wire**.

“Halt, **commoner!**” Leon commanded. “You are entering the **sacred** hall of the New Martian **Empire**. Show some **respect**.”

Aris sighed. “Leon, it’s just the cafeteria. And why are you sitting like that?”

“I am establishing a new **civilization**,” Leon declared, gesturing with a plastic spoon like it was a royal scepter. “We cannot rely on Earth’s outdated **traditions** or **customs**. We need a cultural **renaissance**. I am the **emperor**, the **monarch** of this metal box. You, Aris, are my loyal **subject**, or perhaps my **servant**... no, let’s say **prime minister**.”

“I prefer **colleague**,” Aris muttered.

“Silence!” Leon stood up. “In this **hierarchy**, I have the highest **status** and **prestige**. We are returning to a form of enlightened **feudalism**. I am the **lord**, and you are the... well, you do the work, so you are the **peasant**. But a well-paid one!”

“This sounds like **slavery** with extra steps,” Aris argued. “And what about our **heritage**? We are ambassadors of Earth. We represent democracy and **liberty**.”

“Democracy is slow,” Leon waved his hand. “My **regime** is efficient. Now, let’s discuss **etiquette**. From now on, whenever you approach me, you must perform a specific **ritual**. You must **bow** three times and offer a **tribute**—preferably a coffee.”

Aris rolled his eyes. “This is a **cult**, not a culture.”

“Speaking of culture,” Leon continued, ignoring him. “I have decided that English is too inefficient. We need a new **language** to **unite** our future Martian colony. I call it ‘Leonish’.”

Leon walked to a whiteboard covered in strange drawings. “Look at these **symbols**. I have replaced the **alphabet** with **pictographs** based on my face. This smiling face means ‘Good morning’, and this angry face means ‘The engine is on fire’.”

“That’s not a language; that’s just emojis,” Aris critiqued. “A real language needs complex **grammar**, **syntax**, and a rich **vocabulary**. It evolves through **usage** over centuries. You can’t just invent a **dialect** overnight.”

“Watch me,” Leon grinned. “In Leonish, we don’t use **verbs**. We use **gestures**. It’s all about **non-verbal** communication. For example, wiggling your **thumb** means ‘I agree’.”

“And what about **pronunciation**?” Aris asked. “Or **intonation**?”

“We speak in a high-pitched **accent** to simulate the thin atmosphere of Mars,” Leon demonstrated, squeaking like a mouse. “It distinguishes the **elite** from the **vulgar** masses.”

Aris rubbed his temples. “Leon, if we meet **aliens**, and you speak to them like that, they will think we are **lunatics** (insane). They won’t see us as a **superior** species; they’ll see us as a snack.”

“Nonsense,” Leon sat back on his throne. “Future **generations** will look back at this moment as the **origin** of a great **dynasty**. My **descendants**—or rather, my clones—will worship me as a **legend**, a **myth**.”

“Right now,” Aris said, grabbing a packet of dried food. “The only **myth** is your sanity. I’m going to eat my lunch. In **private**.”

“Wait!” Leon shouted. “You forgot the **ritual**! And you didn’t wiggle your **thumb**!”

Aris walked out, wondering if **mutiny** (rebellion) was a viable option in space.

CHAPTER 6.

The Great Space Jam

Focus: Entertainment & Sports, Art & Music

Plot: Boredom strikes. Zero-gravity Olympics.

Location: The Cargo Bay (converted into a “Multipurpose Stadium”).

“Welcome, **ladies and gentlemen**—and mutant goats!” Leon’s voice boomed over the **loud-speaker**. He was standing on a floating platform, holding a **microphone**. “Today, we make history. Welcome to the first annual Ark **Olympic Games!**”

Aris floated into the room, looking tired. “Leon, there are only two of us. How can we have a **competition?**”

“Details, details,” Leon waved his hand. “We need **recreation**. We need to maintain our **physical fitness**. Plus, the Lio-sheep is an excellent **athlete**. Look at those muscles.”

Leon pointed to the mutant lion-sheep, which was currently chewing on a **volleyball** net.

“First event: Zero-Gravity **Tennis!**” Leon announced. He tossed a **racket** to Aris. “The rules are simple. You hit the ball over the net. If you **drift** into the ceiling, you lose a point.”

Aris sighed but grabbed the **racket**. He missed **exercise**. He tried to **serve**, throwing the ball up. But in zero-G, the ball didn’t come down. It just **hovered** there. Leon seized the moment, swung his racket, and performed a violent **smash**. The ball flew past Aris, bounced off the wall, hit a **drum** kit in the corner, and landed in Leon’s hand.

“Point to me!” Leon shouted. “I am the **champion!** The crowd goes wild!” He pressed a button, and a recording of **cheering spectators** played loudly.

Next came the **marathon**. Since they couldn’t run far, Leon set up two treadmills. “We will **jog** in place for four hours,” Leon said. “Keep a steady **pace** and maintain your **rhythm**.”

Ten minutes later, Leon got bored. “This is dull. Let’s switch to the Arts **Festival**.”

He dimmed the lights and turned on a **spotlight**. “Behold, my **gallery**.”

He pulled a sheet off a pile of twisted metal, broken wires, and old food wrappers. “I call this **sculpture** ‘*The Agony of a Lost Wi-Fi Signal*’. It is a masterpiece of **abstract art**. Notice the **aesthetic** balance between the **garbage** and the **void**.”

Aris stared at the pile of trash. “It looks like a broken **toaster** stuck to a **shoe**.”

“You are no **critic**,” Leon scoffed. “You lack **artistic** vision. Now, prepare yourself for the highlight of the evening: The **Concert**.”

Leon floated over to a collection of instruments he had **improvised** from spare ship parts. There was a “guitar” made of a shovel and rubber bands, and a “drum” made of empty water tanks.

“I will now **perform a solo**,” Leon announced. “It is a fusion of **classical, jazz, rock, and hip-hop**. I call it ‘Space Noise’.”

He started to play. It was loud. It was chaotic. There was no **melody**, no **tune**, and certainly no **harmony**. He banged on the **drum** while screaming unintelligible **lyrics** into the mic.



“Listen to that **rhythm**!” Leon yelled, strumming his shovel-guitar. “I am a musical **genius**! I am better than any **band** on Earth! I am the new **Pop King**!”

The Lio-sheep, unable to bear the noise, let out a deafening **roar** that sounded surprisingly like a **trumpet**.

“Ah,” Leon stopped playing. “The **audience** is participating! A true **symphony** of nature and machine!”

Aris floated over to the **piano** (which was actually just a keyboard painted on a table). “Leon, please. Let’s just watch a **movie**. Do we have any **films** in the database?”

“Fine,” Leon pouted, putting down his shovel. “But nothing boring. I want action, **drama, comedy, and tragedy** all in one.”

They settled down to watch an old **animation**. But as the opening credits rolled, Aris noticed something strange on the screen.

“Leon,” Aris pointed. “Why is the **conductor** of the **orchestra** in the movie wearing a gas mask?”

Leon froze. “Wait. That’s not the movie. That’s a reflection.” He sniffed the air. “Do you smell burning plastic?”

“You overloaded the **circuits** with your electric shovel!” Aris screamed. “The kitchen **fuse** just blew!”

“Well,” Leon shrugged. “At least the **show** ended with a bang.”

CHAPTER 7.

Kitchen Nightmares

Focus: Food & Health, Body & Mind

Plot: Food synthesizer failure. Sickness ensues.

Location: The Galley (Kitchen).

The air in the kitchen smelled of burnt **toast** and melted **plastic**. The ChefBot 3000 was sputtering, its **lid** flapping open and closed like a hungry bird.

“I am **starving**,” Leon announced, tapping his **cutlery** (a **fork** and a **spoon**) against an empty **plate**. “I demand a **banquet**. I want a three-course **meal** with **appetizers**, a main **dish**, and a **dessert**.”

Aris looked at the smoking machine. “Leon, the **recipe** database is corrupted. The machine doesn’t know the difference between a **tomato** and a **potato**. It might **poison** us.”

“Nonsense,” Leon scoffed. “I am a **gourmet**. I have a refined **palate**. I can appreciate any **cuisine**, even experimental ones. ChefBot, **serve** dinner!”

The machine whirred. It didn’t **bake**, **fry**, or **roast**. It just... *extruded*.

SPLAT.

A pile of grey sludge landed in a **bowl**.

“Ah,” Leon peered at it. “It looks like... **porridge**? Or maybe mashed **eggplant**?”

Aris sniffed it. “It smells like **vinegar** mixed with old **socks**.”

“Don’t be picky,” Leon said, grabbing a **knife**. He sliced a piece of something that looked like a **sausage** but smelled like **vanilla ice cream**. “This is fusion food! Look, here is a **sandwich** made of **beef**, **strawberry jam**, and... is that **mustard**?”

Leon took a big bite. He **chewed** vigorously. He **swallowed**. His face turned green.

“Interesting **flavor**,” Leon wheezed, clutching his **throat**. “It’s a bit... **sour**. And **bitter**. And... oh god.”

“Don’t eat it!” Aris yelled, but he was too hungry. He grabbed a **biscuit** that looked safe. It turned out to be a block of compressed **salt** and **pepper**. He choked, grabbing a **mug** of **beverage** to wash it down. It was hot **ketchup** mixed with **coffee**.

Ten minutes later, the **buffet** was over, and the **suffering** began.

Aris lay on the floor, holding his **stomach** (abdomen). “I think I have **food poisoning**.”

“Me too,” Leon groaned, lying on the **bench**. “My **abdomen** feels like it’s exploding. I feel **nauseous** (sick).”

Aris tried to check his own **symptoms**. “My **headache** is splitting. I feel **dizzy**. My **vision** is blurry. Leon, check my **pulse**.”

Leon crawled over, his hand shaking. He touched Aris’s **wrist**. “Your **heartbeat** is irregular. You have a **fever**. Your **forehead** is burning hot. You are definitely **ill**.”

“My **intestines** are twisting,” Aris moaned. “I think my **liver** and **kidneys** are shutting down. That ‘sausage’ was toxic waste!”

“We need **medical** attention,” Leon said, trying to stand up but failing due to **fatigue**. “I am the ship’s **physician** now. Where is the **first aid kit**?”

He dragged a box over. It contained random items: a box of **aspirin** (pills), a bottle of **cough syrup**, some **bandages**, and a large **syringe** (for injections).

“Okay,” Leon said, putting on a **mask**. “I will **diagnose** you. You have Acute Space Indigestion. The **remedy** is... everything in this box.”

“No!” Aris shouted weakly. “Just give me some water to flush out the **toxins**. I need to **digest** this mess.”

“I prescribe a strict **diet**,” Leon muttered, swallowing a **pill** himself. “From now on, we are **vegetarians**. No... **fruitarians**. We only eat **apples** and **pears**. No more **dairy**, no **cheese**, no **butter**, and definitely no experimental **seafood**.”

“We don’t have apples,” Aris reminded him. “We only have those mutant **cabbages** in the greenhouse.”

“Then we eat cabbage soup,” Leon sighed, closing his eyes. “For the rest of the **voyage**. It’s vital for our **fitness** and **hygiene**.”

Aris curled up in pain. “If I **survive** this, I’m going to sue you for **malpractice**.”

“Rest now,” Leon whispered, drifting into a **coma** -like sleep. “Tomorrow, we start our **recovery**. Or we die. Either way, no more cooking.”

CHAPTER 8.

Mars BnB

Focus: Architecture, Transport/Travel

Plot: Landing on Mars. Building the base.

Location: The Surface of Mars (Utopia Planitia).

“Attention, **passengers**,” Leon announced over the intercom, even though Aris was sitting right next to him. “We are approaching our **destination**. Please fasten your seatbelts and stow your **luggage** in the overhead **rack**. We may experience a slight **delay** due to a dust storm on the **route**.”

The **shuttle** (a smaller **vehicle** detached from The Ark) shook violently as it entered the thin Martian atmosphere.

“Leon, slow down!” Aris yelled. “You are coming in too fast! The **landing** gear won’t hold!”

“Relax,” Leon grinned, steering with one hand. “I’m an excellent **pilot**. I’m aiming for that flat **site** near the **canyon**. It’s the perfect location for a **resort**.”

BOOM!

The shuttle slammed into the red dust, bounced twice, and skidded to a **halt** near a pile of rocks.

“We have **arrived**,” Leon said, dusting off his jacket. “Welcome to Mars **Harbour**. Please check that you haven’t left any personal items on the **craft**.”

They stepped out. The **landscape** was desolate but majestic.

“Okay,” Leon clapped his hands. “Time to **construct** our new home. Aris, unload the ‘Instant-City’ modules from the **cargo** hold.”

Aris dragged out several heavy crates. “We need a basic **shelter** first. A secure **dwelling** to protect us from radiation and cold. Maybe a small **hut** or a **cabin**.”

“Think bigger, Aris!” Leon pressed a button on a remote. “I didn’t travel 140 million miles to live in a **shed**. I’m building a **villa**.”

One of the crates exploded open. Nanobots swarmed out, assembling materials. In minutes, a structure began to rise. It wasn’t a simple base; it was a monstrosity.

It had a grand **entrance** with tall **marble columns** (fake marble, actually plastic). It had a **lobby** with a crystal **chandelier** (which didn’t sparkle because there was no light). It even had a **balcony** overlooking the dusty **plain**.

“Behold!” Leon gestured. “The Musk Mansion. It features a spacious **living room**, a **master bedroom**, and a **guest suite** for you.”

Aris walked inside. “Leon, this is ridiculous. Where is the **infrastructure**? Where is the **plumbing**? Where is the **sewage** system?”

“Details,” Leon waved him off. “Check out the **elevator**. It goes up to the **terrace** on the roof.”

“It’s a two-**storey** building,” Aris pointed out. “We can use the **stairs**.”

“We also have a **commercial** wing,” Leon continued. “Over there, I plan to build a **mall** and a **casino**. And maybe a **stadium** for the Lio-sheep to play **soccer**.”

Aris inspected the **foundation**. It looked shaky. The **concrete** was setting too fast in the cold. “Leon, this **structure** is unstable. The **ceiling** is sagging. And you put the **toilet** in the **kitchen**!”

“It’s an open-concept **layout**,” Leon argued. “Very modern. Very **urban** style.”

“We are in a **rural** desert!” Aris shouted. “We need a **warehouse** for food storage, a **greenhouse** for the plants, and a **power plant** for electricity. Instead, you built a **skyscraper** that is only two floors high!”

Suddenly, a warning siren wailed from the shuttle. “*Warning: Sandstorm approaching. **Visibility** zero.*”

“Quick!” Aris pushed Leon inside. “Seal the **shutters**! Lock the **gate**!”

They huddled in the **corridor**, the safest place in the “mansion.” The wind howled outside, battering the **walls** and **roof**.

“Well,” Leon whispered in the dark. “At least the **location** is prime. Once the storm clears, the property value will skyrocket. We can rent out the spare **apartment** on Airbnb.”

“Who are we going to rent it to?” Aris asked. “The aliens?”

“You never know,” Leon smirked. “I put up a **signpost** near the landing zone. ‘Vacancy. Free Wi-Fi.’ They’ll come.”

CHAPTER 9.

The Republic of Two

Focus: Government, Law, Economy

Plot: Society of two needs laws and money.

Location: The Grand Hall of the Musk Mansion (a.k.a. the living room).

The sun rose over the red horizon. Aris walked into the living room to find Leon sitting behind a desk, wearing a sash that said “Supreme Leader.”

“Good morning, **citizen**,” Leon said solemnly. “I have stayed up all night drafting the **Constitution**.”

“The what?” Aris asked, yawning.

“The **Constitution** of the United **Republic** of Mars,” Leon held up a piece of napkin with scribbles on it. “We need a formal **government** to maintain **order** and **stability**. I have appointed myself as the **President**, the **Prime Minister**, and the **Minister** of Defense.”

“And what am I?” Aris asked.

“You are the **population**,” Leon replied. “And also the **Vice Minister** of Sanitation (cleaning toilets). Congratulations on your **appointment**.”

Aris rolled his eyes. “Leon, this isn’t a **democracy**; it’s a **dictatorship** (implied by **regime**). I demand an **election**.”

“We can hold a **vote** later,” Leon dismissed him. “But first, we must discuss the **economy**. Our **society** needs a **currency** to facilitate **trade**.”

Leon opened a suitcase full of plastic chips. “I introduce to you: The Leon-Coin. It is the official **legal** tender of Mars.”

“This is ridiculous,” Aris said. “We don’t need money. We just share resources.”

“That sounds like **socialism**,” Leon narrowed his eyes. “In my **capitalist system**, everything has a price. For example, I own the **infrastructure**, including the air scrubbers. Therefore, I am imposing a **tax** on oxygen.”

“You can’t **tax** air!” Aris shouted. “That violates my basic **human rights**!”

“I have the **authority**,” Leon tapped a gavel (a hammer). “If you cannot pay, you will go into **debt**. But don’t worry, the **Bank** of Leon offers **loans** with a very reasonable 50% **interest** rate.”

Aris was furious. “I refuse to pay! I am going on **strike**!”

“Then you are breaking the **law**,” Leon stood up. “I accuse you of **tax evasion** and **treason**. As the **police** chief, I hereby **arrest** you.”

Leon tried to handcuff Aris with a zip-tie. Aris pushed him away.

“I demand a **trial**!” Aris yelled. “I want a **lawyer** and a **jury**!”

“Fine,” Leon sat back down. “The **court** is now in **session**. I am the **judge**. The **jury** consists of the Lio-sheep and Gary the giant salamander.”

“This **judicial** process is a joke,” Aris protested. “You are the **plaintiff**, the **judge**, and the **witness**? There is no **justice** here! This is a **corrupt regime**!”

“Silence in the court!” Leon banged the table. “The **evidence** is clear. You consumed 500 liters of my oxygen without **payment**. The **verdict** is... **guilty**. Your **sentence** is hard **labor**—you must clean the solar panels for a month.”

“I appeal!” Aris shouted. “I challenge your **legitimacy**. I hereby declare a **revolution**!”

Aris grabbed the bag of Leon-Coins and threw them out the window.

“My **capital**!” Leon screamed, watching his **wealth** scatter in the Martian wind. “You just caused **hyper-inflation**! The **market** will crash!”

“Power to the people!” Aris chanted. “I am organizing a **campaign** for a new leader.”

“Fine!” Leon crossed his arms. “Let’s vote. Who votes for me?” Leon raised his hand. “Who votes for Aris?” Aris raised his hand.

“It’s a tie,” Leon grumbled. “We have a **political** deadlock. The **parliament** is hung.”

Suddenly, the Lio-sheep walked in, ate the **Constitution** (the napkin), and burped.

“I think the **supreme court** just overruled us both,” Aris noted.

“Okay,” Leon sighed, taking off his sash. “New **policy**. No taxes. But you still have to cook dinner. That’s a **mandatory regulation**.”

“Deal,” Aris agreed. “But if you try to sell me water again, I will **sue** you. He tried to mint coins. “This is the new **currency**,” he said. Aris pointed out the **inflation** risks since there were no goods to buy.

CHAPTER 10.

The Mutiny

Focus: War/Conflict, Actions

Plot: Mutant animals revolt. Action sequences.

Location: The Musk Mansion, Mars.

The morning started with an ominous silence. Aris walked into the kitchen and found the Lio-sheep standing on the table. It was **glaring** at him. Its eyes were no longer the eyes of a dumb beast; they were full of **hatred** and **intelligence**.

“Shoo!” Aris waved his hand. “Get down!”

The Lio-sheep didn’t move. Instead, it let out a low **growl** (roar) that sounded like a **threat**. Suddenly, Gary the giant salamander kicked open the door. A **troop** of mutant chickens marched in, their beaks sharp as **blades**.

“Leon!” Aris **shouted**, backing away. “We have a problem!”

Leon rushed in, wearing his pajamas. “What is this **disturbance**? Why are you **interrupting** my beauty sleep?”

“It’s a **revolt**!” Aris cried. “The animals are staging a **mutiny**!”

“Ridiculous,” Leon **scoffed**. He walked up to the Lio-sheep. “Listen here, you **rebel**. I am your **general**, your creator! I **command** you to **cease** this behavior immediately!”

The Lio-sheep **snatched** Leon’s “Supreme Leader” sash with its teeth and ripped it apart. It was a clear act of **treason**.

“Okay,” Leon whispered, his face pale. “That was **aggressive**. They are **hostile**. Aris, prepare for **battle**.”

“With what?” Aris asked, **trembling** (shaking).

“We need **weapons**,” Leon said. He ran to the closet and **equipped** himself with a tennis racket (now a **shield**) and a modified leaf-blower (now a **cannon**). He handed Aris a bottle of spicy sauce. “This is your **pistol**. Aim for the eyes.”

The animals launched their **attack**. It was a **fierce assault**. The chickens fired **missiles** (eggs) with deadly accuracy. Gary the salamander used his tail to **smash** the furniture.

“Defend the perimeter!” Leon yelled, trying to **deter** the chickens with a blast of air. “Do not let them **invade** the living room!”

But the **enemy** had a **strategy**. While the chickens distracted them, the Lio-sheep led a **flank** attack (side attack) and **seized** the refrigerator.

“They captured the food supply!” Aris screamed. “This is a **catastrophe**! We will **starve**!”

“Do not **panic**!” Leon **roared**, trying to **rally** his courage. “We must **counter**-attack! Charge!”

Leon **dashed** forward, swinging his racket. He tried to **strike** Gary, but the slippery amphibian **dodged** and **whipped** Leon’s legs. Leon **tumbled** (fell) to the ground.

“I am **wounded**!” Leon cried dramatically, holding his knee (which was just slightly **bruised**). “Aris, save me!”

Aris looked at the chaos. The room was in **turmoil**. The **violence** was escalating. He realized they couldn’t **defeat** this army. The animals were too **sturdy** and **reckless**.

“We have to **retreat**!” Aris grabbed Leon by the collar and started to **drag** him. “Fall back to the greenhouse! It’s our only **refuge**!”

They **fled** down the corridor, dodging flying eggs. The animals **pursued** them, **barking** and **hissing** in **triumph**.

Aris slammed the heavy glass door of the greenhouse and **locked** it. He **leaned** against it, panting. Outside, the Lio-sheep **stared** at them through the glass, a look of **victory** on its face. It had **conquered** the mansion.

“We are under **siege**,” Leon gasped, looking at the army **surrounding** their glass prison. “They have cut off our supplies. It’s a **conspiracy**. They planned this.”

“Why?” Aris asked, wiping sweat from his brow. “Why did they **rebel**?”

Leon looked through the glass. The Lio-sheep was currently trying to turn on the TV.

“I think...” Leon muttered. “I think they just wanted to watch the cartoons we watched in Chapter 6. I **prohibited** them from watching TV last night.”

“You started a **war** over cartoons?” Aris **glared** at him.

“I’m a **strict** parent,” Leon shrugged. “But now, we are **destitute**. We are **prisoners** in our own ship. We have lost our **freedom**.”

“We have to **negotiate**,” Aris said, holding up a white towel (a sign of **surrender**). “We have to **compromise**.”

Leon sighed. “Fine. I will **offer** them Netflix password. But I refuse to **bow** to a sheep.”

CHAPTER 11.

Reflections on Time

Focus: Time, Emotions/Abstract

Plot: Reflection and nostalgia.

Location: Inside the Greenhouse, looking out at the Martian night sky.

It was **midnight**. Or maybe it was **midday**. It was hard to tell. On Mars, the **daily** cycle was slightly longer than on Earth, throwing their biological clock into chaos.

Leon sat on a sack of fertilizer, staring at the stars. His usual **energetic** and **hectic mood** had vanished. He looked **gloomy**, **miserable**, and strangely **quiet**.

“Aris,” Leon broke the **silence**. “Do you know what date it is?”

“I’ve lost track,” Aris sighed, checking his watch. “The **battery** died a **century** ago. Or maybe just a week. Time feels **everlasting** here. It stretches out into an infinite **duration**.”

“On Earth,” Leon whispered, “it would be the **anniversary** of my company’s founding. Usually, I would be hosting an **annual** gala. There would be **music**, **laughter**, and **champagne**. I would be the **center** of attention, looking **confident** and **proud**.”

He looked down at his torn clothes. “Now, look at me. I look **wretched** and **awkward**. My **reputation** is ruined. I bet the **contemporary** media is calling me a **failure**. They probably think I’m **insane** or **mad**.”

Aris looked at Leon. For the first time, he didn’t feel **anger** or **hatred**. He felt **sympathetic**.

“Leon,” Aris said gently. “You are **arrogant**, **selfish**, and **stubborn**. You are often a **nuisance** and a **bother**. But you are also **enterprising**. You dared to come here. That is not **negligible**.”

Leon managed a weak smile. “You are being **frank**.”

“I’m being **honest**,” Aris sat next to him. “Initially, I was **reluctant** to come. I was **hesitant** and **skeptical**. I felt **resentment** (bitterness) towards you. But in the **midst** of all this chaos, I realized something. We are living in a new **era**.”

“A **medieval** era,” Leon grumbled. “Ruled by chickens.”

“Perhaps,” Aris chuckled. “But think about it. We are the **foremost** humans on this planet. Every **moment** we survive is a **precedent**. We are creating history **simultaneously** with our suffering.”

Leon looked out the glass. The Lio-sheep was sleeping near the door. The **hostile** atmosphere had temporarily calmed down.

“I feel **guilty**,” Leon confessed, his voice **trembling**. “I was **greedy**. I wanted **fame** and **fortune**. I was **indifferent** to the risks. I **ignored** your warnings. I was **rash** and **reckless**. Now, I **regret** everything. I am **ashamed**.”

Aris patted his shoulder. “Don’t **weep**, Leon. It’s **useless** to **mourn** the past. The **former** world is behind us. We have to focus on the **present** and the **imminent** future.”

“Do you think we have a future?” Leon asked, sounding **pessimistic** and **desperate**. “The animals are **sturdy** and **vicious**. Our situation is **unstable**.”

“I am **optimistic**,” Aris said, pointing at a small blue dot in the sky. “Look. That’s Earth. It looks so **peaceful**, so **delicate**. It reminds me that our problems are **temporary**. We just need to be **patient** and **rational**.”

Leon gazed at the pale blue dot. A wave of **nostalgia** (homesickness) washed over him. He felt a deep **yearning** for home.

“You are right,” Leon wiped his eyes. “I shouldn’t be **passive**. I need to be **positive**. I need to regain my **zeal**. We will survive this.”

“**Incidentally**,” Aris added. “I think the Lio-sheep likes music. Remember the concert? It stopped attacking when you played the **rhythm**. Maybe we can tame them.”

Leon’s eyes lit up. His **enthusiastic personality** returned **immediately**.

“Music!” Leon jumped up. “Of course! I am a musical **genius**! I will compose a **symphony** of peace! It will be **glorious**! It will be **awesome**!”

Aris smiled. The old, annoying Leon was back. But this time, Aris felt a sense of **mutual** understanding. They were partners in this **ridiculous** fate.

“Okay, Mozart,” Aris stood up. “Let’s wait for **dawn**. Tomorrow, we negotiate with the chickens. But for the **meantime**, let’s get some sleep.”

“Goodnight, Aris,” Leon said, sounding **sincere**. “And... thank you. For being **tolerant**.”

“Goodnight, Mr. President,” Aris replied.

Outside, the wind howled, but inside, there was finally a sense of **harmony**.

CHAPTER 12.

Grand Finale

Focus: Review of difficult words

Plot: Wrapping up the story.

Location: The Terrace of the Musk Mansion (at sunrise).

The Martian sun peeked over the **horizon**, casting a long **shadow** across the red **plain**. The **atmosphere** was tense but hopeful. Leon stood on the **balcony**, holding his “shovel-guitar.” Aris stood beside him, holding a **flag** made of a white bedsheet—a symbol of **peace** and **surrender**.

“Are you ready?” Aris asked.

“I was born ready,” Leon adjusted his tattered **collar**. “This will be my greatest **performance**.”

Below them, the army of mutant animals waited. The Lio-sheep looked up, its expression **stern** but **curious**. Gary the salamander was chewing on a piece of **cable**.

Leon took a deep breath and struck a chord. *TWANG!*

It wasn’t perfect, but it was... **musical**. He began to play a slow, **gentle melody**. It wasn’t the chaotic noise from before. It was a **sincere** tune, full of **emotion**.

“Friends!” Leon sang (surprisingly in **tune**). “Why do we **fight**? Why do we **quarrel**? We are all stuck on this rock together! Let us **unite**!”

The chickens stopped clucking. The Lio-sheep sat down. The **rhythm** seemed to **soothe** their savage **instincts**.

Aris joined in, tapping a **rhythm** on a plastic **bucket**. “We offer you **freedom**! We offer you **respect**! No more **cages**! No more **chains**!”

It worked. The animals didn’t **attack**. Instead, the Lio-sheep let out a soft **moan** (a happy sound) and wagged its tail. The **hostility** vanished. The **siege** was over.

“We did it!” Leon whispered, tears of **joy** in his eyes. “We achieved **harmony**!”

Just then, a loud **boom** echoed through the **valley**. A bright light flashed in the sky.

“Is that a **meteorite**?” Aris gasped.

“No,” Leon squinted. “It’s a **spaceship**.”

A sleek, silver vessel descended and **landed** gracefully near their wrecked shuttle. The door opened, and a **delegation** of humans in pristine white **uniforms** walked out.

“Dr. Aris? Mr. Husk?” the leader of the group asked. “I am Captain Nova from the Earth Rescue **Mission**. We received your **distress** signal... three months ago. Sorry for the **delay**. Traffic was terrible near the Moon.”

Leon dropped his shovel. “Rescue? We are saved!”

“We are here to take you home,” Captain Nova said, looking around at the ruined mansion, the mutant chickens, and the two dirty, bearded men. “Although... it looks like you have established a... unique **community** here.”

Leon looked at Aris. Then he looked at the Lio-sheep, who was now nuzzling his leg. He looked at the ugly, half-finished **villa** they had built with their own hands.

“Go home?” Leon hesitated. “Back to the **taxes**, the **paparazzi**, and the boring **board** meetings?”

Aris looked at the red **landscape**. It was harsh, **barren**, and **dangerous**. But it was also theirs. They had survived **disasters**, **diseases**, and **mutinies**. They had created a **language**, a **government** (sort of), and a new **species**.

“Actually,” Aris said, surprising himself. “We have a lot of **unfinished** business here. We need to **restore** the greenhouse. We need to **educate** the chickens. We have a **vision** for this planet.”

“You mean...” Leon grinned. “We stay?”

“We stay,” Aris nodded. “This is our **colony**. Our **legacy**.”

Leon turned to Captain Nova. “Thank you, Captain. But we **decline** your offer. However, could you leave us some supplies? Specifically, **chocolate**, **shampoo**, and a real **guitar**?”

Captain Nova looked confused but agreed. The crew unloaded crates of **necessities** and took off, leaving the two pioneers behind.

As the ship disappeared into the **cosmos**, Leon put his arm around Aris’s shoulder.

“Well, Mr. Prime Minister,” Leon said. “We have a **nation** to build. What’s the first item on the **agenda**?”

“First,” Aris said, picking up a hammer. “We fix the **toilet**.”

“Agreed,” Leon laughed. “And then... we hold an **election**.”

And so, on the dusty plains of Mars, under the **eternal** gaze of the stars, the absurd adventure of Leon and Aris continued. They were **lonely**, they were **crazy**, but they were **free**.

THE END.